U.S. Milk Production

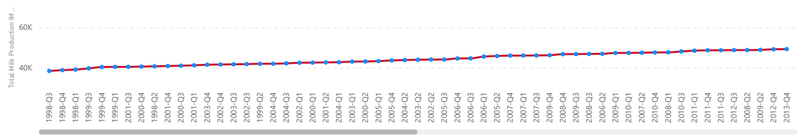
1998–2026 · Source: USDA ERS · Analysis by Reggie

LATEST QUARTER | ANNUAL PRODUCTION | YIELD PER COW | FEED VALUE

Latest Quarter Production	Annual Production Latest Year	Milk per Cow (Latest Quarter)	Feed Value (Latest Quarter)
60,194K	231,66K	6,23K	$9,43

Quarterly Milk Production, 1998–2026

Total Milk Production (M lbs) by YearQuarter



Herd Size vs. Yield per Cow

Total Milk Cows (1,000 head) and Milk per Cow (lbs) by Year

Feed Value, Annual Average ($/cwt)

Feed Value ($/cwt) by Year

Filter by Year

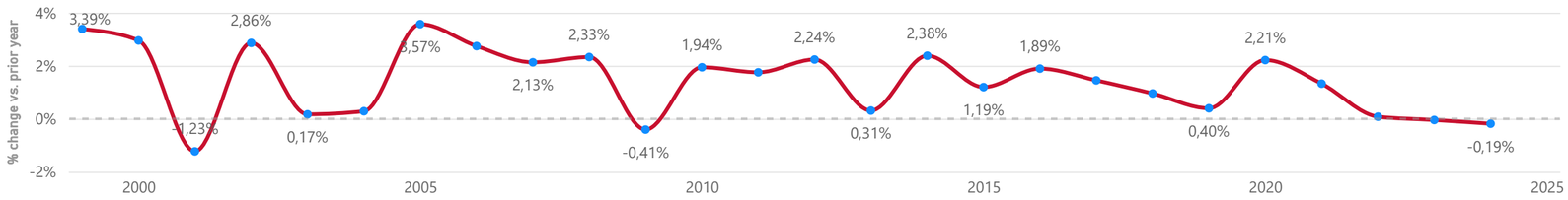
1998 — 2026

Growth & Efficiency

what drove production from 157B lbs to 232B lbs?

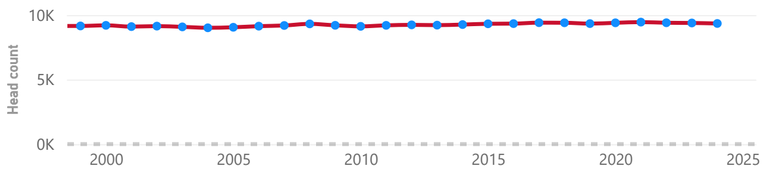
Year-over-Year Production Growth, 1999–2026

Production YoY % by Year



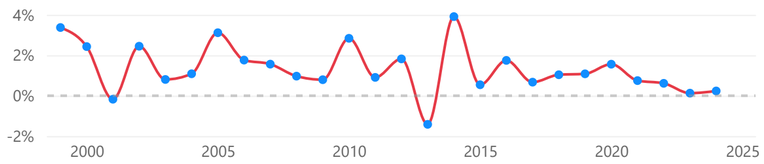
National Herd Size

Total Milk Cows (1,000 head) by Year



Milk per Cow YoY %

by Year



The Yield Engine:
The U.S. milk cow herd has hovered between 9,000 and 9,500 thousand head since 1998. It contracted during the 2008 financial crisis and recovered slowly, but net herd size is virtually flat. Despite this flat herd, total production grew 47%. The entire gain came from Yield per Cow - which grew 42% (from 17,185 lbs to 24,390 lbs). The industry isn't adding more cows; it is making each cow vastly more productive.

Filter by Year

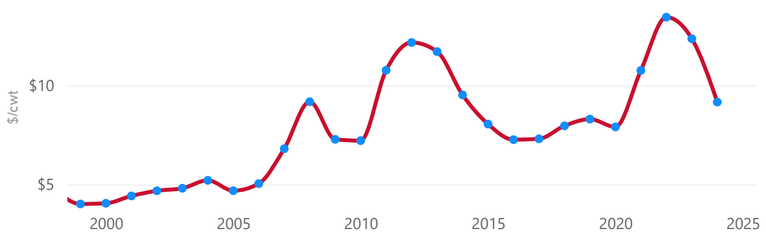
1998 2026

Cost Structure

Tracking feed and replacement cow prices over time

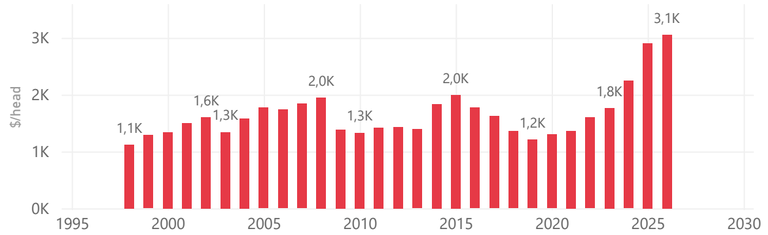
Feed Value, Annual Avg ($/cwt)

Feed Value ($/cwt) by Year



Replacement Cow Price ($/head)

Replacement Cow Price ($/head) by Year



The Cost Squeeze:
Feed is the largest operating expense for dairy farms. In 2008 and 2022, feed value spiked dramatically, squeezing farmer margins and contributing to herd sell-offs. Meanwhile, replacement cow prices have surged since 2020, reaching an all-time high of $3,110/head in 2025. The industry is facing a classic inflation squeeze: higher input costs alongside a shrinking supply of replacement animals.

Filter by Year

1998 2026

Executive Summary & Data Notes

Project methodology, limitations, and key takeaways

Key Findings

- **Production Growth:** U.S. milk production grew 47% from 1998 to 2025 (157B to 232B lbs).
- **The Yield Engine:** The national herd size has remained virtually flat (~9,200-9,500 head). The entire production gain was driven by a 42% increase in yield per cow (17,185 to 24,390 lbs).
- **Cost Pressures:** Feed costs are highly volatile, peaking in 2008 and 2022. Replacement cow prices have surged to all-time highs post-2020, squeezing farmer margins.

Methodology & Data Cleaning

- **Source:** USDA Economic Research Service (Data through Q2 2026).
- **Grain Split:** Separated quarterly and annual rows into two distinct Fact tables to prevent double-counting.
- **Null Handling:** Preserved 2013 Q1–Q2 missing values (unavailable in source) rather than imputing them.
- **Partial Data:** Excluded 2026 from YoY charts as it only contains half a year of data.
- **Limitation:** No milk price data is present, so the classic USDA milk-feed ratio cannot be calculated.

1.

Year	Annual Milk Production (M lbs)	Total Milk Cows (1,000 head)	Milk per Cow (lbs)
2025	231 658,00	9 497,75	6 098,00
1998	157 262,00	9 150,50	4 296,50